Building for ActCAD, or building for the world?

A directors briefing — for discussion

Working brand TejasCAD, pending TM clearance.

ITC pricing is what we actually pay. Our own projections are illustrative.

The decision on the table

- We are **already** re-architecting ActCAD off IntelliCAD. **That continues either way.**
- The question is one level up: **do we build it only for ActCAD, or as a platform other CAD vendors license under their own brand?**
- Every seam we build for ActCAD — tenant profile, licensing, plugin host, AI — **is what a white-label platform needs anyway**
- The market is specific: **~40 ITC members**, **~200 vertical ISVs**, BIM-lite startups
- **“Can we build it” is settled** — Phase 0 ships today

Phase 0 today — what already ships

Six weeks, ~207 commits, 13+ drops to the ActCAD team.

AREA	STATUS
DWG/DXF	Real customer files open in the browser. WASM + ODA inWEB, both live.
Measure / snap / count	Full 14-mode osnap suite, CSV + Excel export
Performance	250K entities at 61 fps; regen 17× faster; instant zoom-extents
3D	Orbit, standard views, ViewCube. Layouts + paper space viewports.
Beyond scope	DWG↔DWG and PDF comparison, colour plotting, batch print, markups
Distribution	Windows MSI shipping. macOS CI green. Android prototype.
Tests	594/594 green, plus a native gate harness
The hard rule	**Read-only guarantee holds. No `db` writes anywhere.**

> **Faster than ActCAD on many customer files — and well ahead of IntelliCAD's viewer and ODA's own.** Before public launch.

Still owed: customer-hardware perf baseline · public launch and adoption signal.

Architecture for the editor

Some ODA features are not exposed to the web stack. The full editor needs a **native** path.

- **Now → viewer launch** — continue on Rust/Tauri + WASM/inWEB. Ship it.
- **After launch** — **migrate the full product to Qt + C++ native.** This is where the missing ODA surface becomes available, and where the ActCAD team wants to be long term.
- **The web viewer** — either folds into the Qt stack as a second frontend on the same C++ engine, or stays on Rust/Tauri. **Decide with data during the migration.**

> **The platform seams — tenant profile, licensing, marketplace, AI agent — live in the C++ core regardless of which shell wraps them.**

The case against — stated at full strength

1. **We are a CAD company, not a platform company.** Different sales motion, different support model, skills we have never had.
2. **It distracts from what matters.** ActCAD-new reaching GA is the priority. **The real cost is management attention.**
3. **The money is not transformational.** Partner obligations and a second entity for a few million a year.
4. **We would be arming competitors** — especially by licensing our verticals.
5. **Members will constrain our roadmap.** Once they pay, we are less free to choose.
6. **Nobody has asked for this.** Zero members, zero LOIs.
7. **ITC members are sticky.** Twenty years in, switching costs are large.
8. **We do not have the team.** A platform team has to be hired from scratch.

> **2, 3, 5, 6 and 8 are substantially correct.**

Why we still think yes

OBJECTION	ANSWER
Not a platform company	**True.** But nothing before month 24 requires becoming one.
Distracts from ActCAD	**Partly conceded** — attention is the real cost
Money is modest	**Conceded.** Not why we would do it alone.
Arming competitors	Gated by named-competitor exclusion — **or we don’t sell that tier**
Roadmap constraint	**Conceded — the one that worries us most.** Input, never veto.
No demand proven	**Fully conceded. Zero LOIs.** Hence a kill switch at month 24.
Members are sticky	**True** — base case is 12 members in seven years, not fifty
No team	**Conceded.** But **we need that team for ActCAD-new regardless.**

> **Building multi-tenant makes ActCAD better even if no member ever signs.**

The tenant seam touches six of ten modules. Building it now forces no ActCAD-specific hacks in core, a real plugin API, configuration-driven behaviour. **Retrofitting later means reworking those six modules after they harden.**

Who builds it

FUNCTION	WHO
Engine, multi-tenancy, licensing, deep systems	**TejasCAD — dev team to be hired**
QA, release engineering, corpus and regression	**TejasCAD — to be hired**
Dev support, SDK, docs, member L3	**TejasCAD — to be hired**
Domain expertise, verticals, IRX, product judgement	**ActCAD’s team**
Selling ActCAD to end customers	**ActCAD’s sales — unchanged**
A member’s own L1/L2 and end-customer sales	**The member**

> **That team is the engine team.** The platform does not create the cost — ActCAD-new needs those people either way. **It decides who employs them and who else helps pay.**

The kill switch

- **Month 12** — have 8–10 qualified member conversations happened? If not, **stop outbound**
- **Month 24, at ActCAD-new GA — ≥2 members at signed LOI, or we stop.** No platform entity, no partner obligations
- **Before any Complete-tier sale** — does it threaten ActCAD in that territory? If so, **don’t sell it**

> **If month 24 fails, we lose 3–6 engineer-months — spent on architecture we would defend on ActCAD’s own merits anyway.**

- What we keep regardless: **cleanly separated engine, real plugin API, configuration-driven behaviour, proper licensing abstraction**

The two paths

	BUILD FOR ACTCAD ONLY	BUILD AS A PLATFORM
Engine work	Same	Same
Ship date	~24 months to GA	Same, + tenant discipline in P1
Extra P1 cost	Baseline	**~3–6 engineer-months**
Revenue	ActCAD only	**+ member fees, marketplace, vertical royalties**
Exit	ActCAD as one product	**A second, separately saleable asset**
If it fails	—	**We still shipped a great ActCAD**

> **A no forecloses one thing that is hard to reopen: the architecture.** Everything else can be revisited in three years.

What we pay IntelliCAD today

ITC membership + extras	**~$100K / year**
Per-seat royalty to ITC	**$0** — royalty-free at the ITC level
Component royalties (ACIS and others)	**$15–20 per sale**
AI	**~$7–8K/yr extra** — experimental
Android viewer	**~$8K/yr extra** — weak
Mac, web app, web editor	**Not available. Windows-tied.**

> **And what we get for it is ~a million lines of source** — not a product. A codebase to staff, fork and re-merge on every uptake, before selling a single seat.

IntelliCAD++ — what we give that ITC does not

The deliverable	~1M lines of source	**A shipping product you configure**
Engine maintenance	**Yours, forever**	**Ours.** You never touch engine code
Engine bugs	You fix them; **your work reaches competitors**	**We fix them.** You draw from the pool without funding it
Your own plugins & verticals	Intertwined with engine patches	**Stay entirely yours**
Release cadence	Coordinated, annual	**Rolling — ship when ready**
Platform reach	Windows	**Windows, Mac, Linux, web, Android**
AI	~$8K experimental add-on	**Included**
Licensing / DRM	Buy your own	**Included, and platform-blind**
Direction	Member supermajority	Platform decides; **members have voice**

> **The consortium gave members shared ownership of a codebase and sole responsibility for running it. We carry the responsibility instead.**

What we deliver, and what we would charge

Tiers gate on what they take:

TIER	ADDS
Core	Engine, DWG fidelity, white-label shell, build pipeline, licensing, **AI**
Plus	+ web app, **Mac, Android**, marketplace
Complete	+ **the ActCAD-derived verticals** (Arch / Mech / Elec / BIM / GIS)

Priced by the member's own installed base:

SEAT BASE	CORE	PLUS	COMPLETE
Under 5,000	$45K	$65K	$90K
5,000–20,000	$80K	$110K	$150K
20,000–50,000	$130K	**$170K**	$220K
50,000+	$190K	$240K	$300K

- **Ramped 50% / 75% / 100%** over migration years 1–3
- **Component royalties pass through at cost** — no markup
- **AI metered above an allowance**, or bring your own key — inference is a real per-use cost
- **Complete tier is a decision, not just a price** — it arms vendors who may compete with ActCAD

What this could become

	CONSERVATIVE	BASE	AGGRESSIVE
Members by Y7	5	12	20
Blended fee	~$70K	~$110K	~$170K
+ marketplace & royalties	~$15K	~$30K	~$45K
Platform ARR	**~$425K**	**~$1.7M**	**~$4.3M**
Margin	~68%	~70%	~72%
Profit contribution	**~$290K**	**~$1.2M**	**~$3.1M**
Enterprise value at 6–8×	not saleable	~$10–13M	**~$26–34M**

> **A profitable adjacent business line, not a venture-scale company.** Good return on a few engineer-months on an engine we are building anyway.

Materially bigger needs ~60–100 members, direct-to-end-user, or the 3D product — later questions, not assumptions.

Funding

STAGE	WHEN	SIZE
Promoter seed	Now → Y2	**$1–2M** — the increment on an already-funded engine
Strategic round *(optional)*	Y4–5	**$5–10M** — sets a floor, from a plausible acquirer
Exit	Y6–7	Target **$30–50M**

- A priced round's post-money **does** anchor expectations — but only if defensible
- **What forces price up is competition between buyers, not a prior round**
- At ~70% margins this **self-funds from year 3** — take the round for tension, not cash

What we are asking

In-principle approval.

And to open three discussions:

- **Corporate structure**
- **Capital requirement**
- **The team required to make this happen**

Nothing else is being decided today. No capital commitment, no incorporation, no announcement, no change to how ActCAD is run.